Connection: An Important Outcome Measure of Youth Programs

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Research Questions

- How can outdoor programs demonstrate their value and impact on young people?
- Can non-academic, non-cognitive measures (i.e., connection) serve as an alternative approach for evaluating program success?

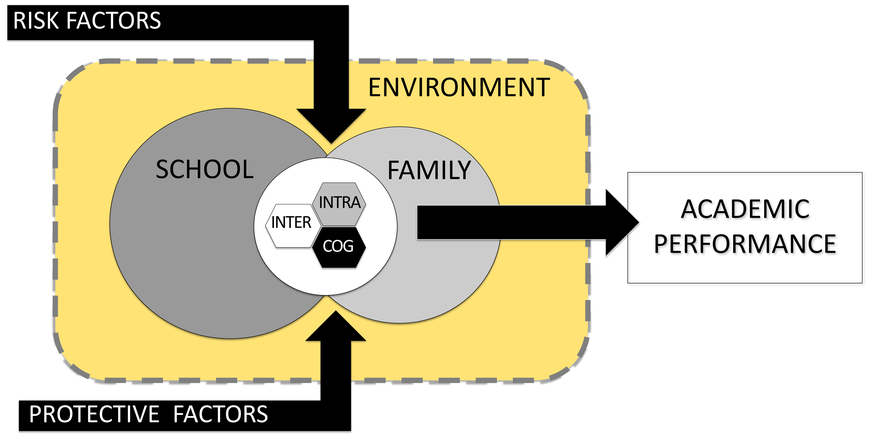


This study examines the impact of outdoor programming on urban youth, using data collected from more than 300 fifth through eighth graders and 23 teachers who participated in the Urban Wilderness Canoe Adventures (UWCA) program. For six hours, students canoed on the Mississippi River during the Minneapolis Public Schools' summer program.

Researchers used student pre- and post-trip surveys and a post-trip teacher survey to assess the impact of an experiential learning canoe trip on participants' connections to others and the influence on teamwork, interest in learning science, and sense of belonging. Results show the student participants developed connections with peers and supportive adults. Nearly four of every five students reported they felt more connected with their peers, adults, and school following the trip. Likewise, improved feelings of connection were associated with increased interest in learning about science, improved teamwork, and increased feelings of belonging. The study provides support for using non-cognitive measures, like connection, to assess the impact of youth programming on young people rather than depending solely on academic outcome measures.

Theoretical Framework

Connection – We define *connection* as interpersonal linkages among people (peers, teachers, trip leaders), as well as, to the environment. Items that serve as indicators of connection include: a sense of belonging, relationships with peers, attitudes about teachers and trip leaders, interest in the environment, working as a team, and the like.



Results

STUDENT SURVEY

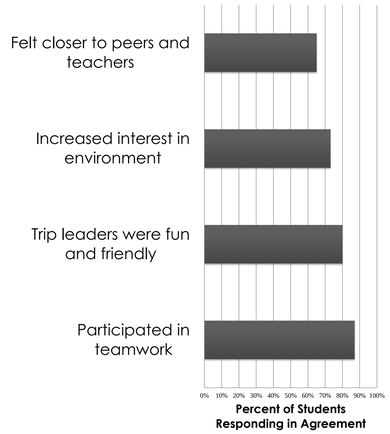
Moderate Positive Relationship between student sense of belonging and:

1) Connection to teachers
2) Ability to work as a team
3) Self-perception of positive qualities

Strong Positive Relationship between the quality of trip leaders and:

1) An interest in continuing to study science
2) Interest in environmental issues
3) Working as a team
4) Acquisition of new skills

Impact of River Trip on Student Perceptions of Connection



TEACHER SURVEY

- Teachers echo these results with over 85% reporting students were engaged and worked well with peers on the trip
- Teachers commented the group leaders were engaging and professional, and100% of teachers agreed the trip leaders were friendly and knowledgeable

Future Directions

More research using non-cognitive intrapersonal and interpersonal predictors of outcomes for out-of-school programs

Continued development of instruments to produce reliable, valid data to assess out-of-school programs

Use of the Combined Ecological-Learning Model as a framework for future research about the impact of connections on student outcomes



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